SAFFRON'S CROSS CONNECTION

THE BJP REALISES THE CHRISTIAN COMMUNITY IS CRUCIAL FOR THE PARTY TO MAKE A BREAKTHROUGH IN KERALA. THE CATHOLIC CHURCH IS ALSO AWARE OF THE ADVANTAGES OF SUCH AN ARRANGEMENT

By Jeemon Jacob

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SEASON'S GREETINGS PM Modi with CBCI office-bearers at the X'mas celebrations in New Delhi, Dec. 23

The '*sneha yatra* (journey of love)', an outreach programme the Kerala BJP started in 2023 during festivals, has found many takers among the state's Christians. The season's greetings messages and party leaders swinging by bishops' houses impressed many of the 'politically neutral' faithful, giving the BJP its first Lok Sabha MP from Kerala, superstar Suresh Gopi, elected from Thrissur where the church holds much clout.

The 2024 *sneha yatra* highlights included Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing the Catholic Bishops' Conference of India's (CBCI) Christmas celebration held at its Delhi headquarters on December 23. He was the first PM to do so. CBCI president and Thrissur archbishop Andrews Thazhath praised Modi, saying his "vision for a united and progressive India echoes the Gospel values of inclusion and service to all". However, he also took care to mention the "concerns of those targeted by anti-social fringe elements".

Those 'concerns' were mostly about the unending violence in Manipur where the largely Chris-